

François Bernier's India

(1658–69 CE)

'The heat is so intense in Hindoustan, that no one, not even the King, wears stockings,' writes Frenchman François Bernier (1625–88) in a letter to a friend back home in the 1660s. For over six months, 'everybody lies in the open air without covering—the common people in the streets, the merchants and persons of condition sometimes in their courts or gardens, and sometimes on their terraces, which are first carefully watered'.[1] Bernier, a medical doctor, was then in Aurangzeb's employ in Shahjahanabad, the new capital of the Mughal Empire in Delhi.

Eager to see the world, Bernier had left France in 1654 and spent a few years in Syria, Palestine, and Egypt, from where he made his way to Surat, Gujarat, in 1658. He stayed in India for twelve years, starting as the personal physician of Dara Shikoh, Emperor Shah Jahan's eldest son. He was in Delhi during the bloody war of royal succession that saw Aurangzeb prevail over his three brothers and imprison his father Shah Jahan—a saga Bernier documented in extensive detail in a letter to a friend.

Bernier then worked for a nobleman in Aurangzeb's court, Daneshmand Khan, secretary of state for foreign affairs and grand master of the horse. In his letters to people back home, later published as *Travels in the Mogul Empire*, Bernier warmly refers to Khan as 'my Agah', 'the most learned man of Asia', 'whose thirst for knowledge is incessant', and who devotes